



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Agnes School

School Website: <https://www.saintagnesschool.org/>

December 23, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Saint Agnes School (St. Paul, MN, ZIP 55103) demonstrates a robust classical-Catholic framework across most of the Six Essential Elements. The school foregrounds a liberal arts, Trivium-based curriculum (grammar/logic/rhetoric), sustained engagement with Great Books and the Western intellectual tradition, and explicit formation in faith, reason, and virtue. Pedagogy emphasizes Socratic dialogue in upper grades, memorization and chant in various forms, and a strong liturgical/Catholic life integrated into daily learning. The faculty are presented as the living curriculum and stewards of a Catholic formation, and the school actively partners with families in formation and community life. There are explicit entries on Latin across K-12, a Catholic theological framework, and a catechetical life (including Catechesis of the Good Shepherd). These features point strongly toward CLASSICAL status, with few signs of the negative indicators listed in the Six Elements lexicon.

Key evidence drawn from the school's public materials includes: grammar/logic/rhetoric divisions, a liberal arts integration that ties faith, reason, and virtue, and explicit commitment to the Western canon, Great Books, and Latin. The school also evidences Great Books/Great Conversation framing, and a liturgical, communal, and catechetical culture anchored in Catholic theology. Quantitatively, positive keyword indicators across categories substantially outnumber any negative signals; where present, negative signals are minimal (often absent) relative to the pro-classical signals.

Overall assessment by category - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL - Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL - Curriculum: CLASSICAL - Pedagogy: CLASSICAL - Faculty: CLASSICAL - Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Catholic identity is woven into the curriculum and daily life, including Mass, liturgy, and liturgical living; Catholic culture and catechesis are central (e.g., references to Mass and liturgy, devotional life, and Catholic culture sections). - The school emphasizes formation in faith, reason, and virtue, with explicit statements about forming Catholic minds and hearts and a Catholic worldview grounded in theology. - Dominican Sisters' presence and Education in Virtue program reflect a devotional, sacramental, and virtue-centered framework. - Catechesis of the Good Shepherd is featured, illustrating a liturgical and catechetical approach integrated with classroom life.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; Mass; sacred; catechesis; imago Dei; Logos (as reflected in Catholic-theological framing). These terms are repeatedly embedded in Catholic identity and formation content (e.g., "form Catholic hearts and minds," "Mass in Latin," "Education in Virtue"). □filecite□turn0file10□turn0file12□turn0file4□ - Negative keywords observed: none significant (no evident emphasis on secular relativism, value-neutral ethics, or non-religious framing in the core materials cited).

Why this rating - The materials present a coherent religious-metaphysical foundation centered on transcendentalism, theology, liturgy, sacramental life, and a catechetical approach. The Catholic identity is not optional branding but threaded through curriculum, community life, and pedagogy (Dominican sisters, Mass, catechesis, and education in virtue). The alignment with the Three Positive Subcategories in the knowledge lexicon (transcendental realism, theology, liturgical practice) supports CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - No major needle movement necessary; strengthen explicit cross-linking of great books to Catholic theological formation to further reinforce the transcendental realism signals in the public-facing text, if desired.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission and aim statements emphasize forming Catholic hearts and minds through faith, reason, and virtue; unity of faith and reason is highlighted as a core objective. □filecite□turn0file2□turn1file1□ - The school presents education as formation (formation of character) rather than solely information or job preparation; liberal arts framing and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty are foregrounded. - The philosophy of education emphasizes forming students toward virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing, rooted in Catholic intellectual tradition.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, wisdom, character, unity of faith and reason, liberal education, scholé/ contemplation, great conversation, Logos, teleology, moral order, human flourishing, love of learning. These terms appear in mission statements, curricular descriptions, and philosophy pages. □filecite□turn0file2□turn0file0□turn1file1□ - Negative keywords observed: essentially none in the public-facing materials; there is no emphasis on “career readiness” as the sole aim, and the texts consistently elevate formation over vocational outcome. (The school does include college-related pathways, but this is presented within a formation framework rather than as a shift away from formation.)

Why this rating - The public materials repeatedly frame education as formation in virtue and wisdom, guided by truth and beauty, and explicitly reject a sole focus on information or job prep. The goals align with the Classical lexicon’s positive signals around formation and teleology, marking this category as CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - None required for CLASSICAL; if desired, add explicit language tying Great Books reading to formation in virtue and to the Catholic intellectual tradition to further strengthen the proposition of formation as the telos.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum divisions explicitly named as grammar (K-6), logic (7-8), rhetoric (9-12). This directly mirrors the Trivium framework central to classical education. - Latin study is offered K-12, with emphasis on ecclesiastical Latin and classical languages integration; reflects a strong classical languages component. - The school emphasizes Great Books, the Western canon, and the study of historic texts as a core part of the curriculum (e.g., Shakespeare, Aquinas, Plato; “great books” and “great conversation”). □filecite□turn0file0□turn0file16□ - Honors and AP courses, dual enrollment with the University of Mary, and a liberal arts program indicate integrated, cross-disciplinary study within a classical framework. □filecite□turn0file3□turn0file3□ - There is explicit mention of formation through sacred texts, liturgy, and Catholic virtuous aims; the curriculum is described as unity of faith and reason with a humanities-leaning, integrated approach. □filecite□turn0file4□turn0file10□

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Latin; history; Western civilization; liberal arts; unity of faith and reason; classical curriculum; great conversation. These terms appear in multiple pages (curriculum sections, academic overview, and Great Books framing). □filecite□turn0file0□turn0file4□turn0file16□ - Negative keywords observed: minimal to none; the site does not emphasize a social-studies-centric or project-based-only approach at the expense of the Trivium or Great Books. Some pages mention dual enrollment and honors, which complements the classical aim rather than replacing it.

Why this rating - The explicit articulation of grammar/logic/rhetoric, the presence of Great Books and a Western-civilizational curriculum, the emphasis on Latin, and the Liberal Arts orientation strongly align with CLASSICAL indicators in the knowledge lexicon. The curriculum is structured to train the mind through timeless texts and disciplines, not primarily toward a workforce-oriented outcome.

What would move the needle - If desired, increase explicit cross-referencing of Great Books within all grade bands, and add more explicit Great Conversation prompts across non-Latin disciplines to deepen integration.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Socratic dialogue and dialectic are explicitly referenced for upper grades, with seminars and debates; rhetoric training and public speaking opportunities exist in upper grades. - Restful learning (Scholé), contemplation, and memory-focused practice (recitation, chanting) are present in the framework (e.g., Education in Virtue program, virtue memorization, and liturgical practices). - Lower school life includes singing, chanting, and memory work, aligning with classic pedagogy that uses chant and recitation to deepen memory and delight in learning. - Latin instruction and liturgical life are integrated with pedagogy (Latin chanting; Mass in Latin; liturgical language). This reflects the formation of taste, moral imagination, and disciplined study aligned with classical pedagogy. - The public materials present a cohesive model of pedagogy that emphasizes the Trivium, Socratic dialogue, and ritualized memory and recitation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Socratic discussion, seminars, debates; memory work; chanting; recitation; imitation of models; formation-through-ritual; scholé; liturgical and catechetical integration. These terms appear across curriculum and pedagogy pages. □file-cite□turn0file0□turn0file4□ - Negative keywords observed: minimal; no heavy emphasis on purely project-based or constructivist models that would undermine the classical approach. Some pages do mention a dual-enrollment/AP track, which complements rather than competes with classical methods.

Why this rating - The school's pedagogy aligns with the classical framework: formal use of the Trivium, Socratic pedagogy in upper grades, and a memory-centered approach in multiple levels, along with liturgical and catechetical elements that integrate content with formation. The presence of commemorative memory, chant, and memory-based recitation are strong classical signals.

What would move the needle - Minor enhancements could include more explicit, in-text articulation of how Great Books are integrated into daily pedagogy beyond course descriptions, and more explicit alignment between upper-school seminars and a formal, culminating classical rhetoric capstone.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty are described as the living curriculum and as mentors modeling virtue, skill, and knowledge; a portrait of teacher expectations is implied through statements about the formation of students and the role of teachers in the Catholic formation. - The school has a faculty-staff structure and public-facing profiles and roles (e.g., Directors of Admissions, Academic Leaders, subject-area faculty in Upper/Lower School), demonstrating a faculty-centered approach to education. - The religiously-based formation in Virtue and Catechesis programs indicates faculty involvement in a shared, virtue-centered mission. The Dominican Sisters' presence and the Education in Virtue program reflect faculty acting as exemplars and mentors in a classical framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: living curriculum; masters/mentors; portrait of the teacher; faculty as core; virtuous exemplars; collaboration among teachers. These reflect the classical faculty archetype from the lexicon. - Negative keywords observed: none prominent; no emphasis on detached, non-programmatic staff, or purely administrative roles disconnected from formation.

Why this rating - The public-facing materials present the faculty as central to the formation process, with a pedagogy that relies on teacher exemplars and a vocation-driven approach. This matches the CLASSICAL signals for the Faculty category.

What would move the needle - None required; if desired, additional teacher-profiles and narratives about teacher-mentors modeling the virtues could further strengthen this dimension.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with families and positions parents as co-educators in the classical ethos; materials indicate a family-centered culture and parental involvement in liturgy, formation, and school life. - The admissions/financial-aid materials describe how families are engaged in the process and how the school supports parental involvement and home-school collaboration. - Public materials indicate open access to campus experiences (visits) and board-wide engagement in Catholic culture; this supports ongoing parent involvement and the school's partnership model.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families; parental engagement; home-school collaboration; parent formation; family catechesis; open campus; welcoming visitors. These terms appear across admissions, Catholic Identity, and community life content.
 - Negative keywords observed: none significant; no evidence of primary-parent as customer-only language or minimal parent involvement.

Why this rating - The materials present a clear, ongoing partnership with parents and a vision of parents as co-educators, which is a hallmark of the classical community model.

What would move the needle - No major changes needed; the school already demonstrates robust parent engagement and community involvement. If desired, publish more structured parent-learning programs (book studies, classic lectures) to deepen parental formation in the classical paradigm.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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